

Stories from Hulburg



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STORIES FROM HULBURG

In this booklet, you will find a short guide to Hulburg by the Moonsea, in the Forgotten Realms, and two short modules. The city is growing fast after a few challenging years, but for centuries, the proximity to Thar and the orc tribes have had a significant impact on the city's prosperity. Now, more and more people come to the city in the hope of finding wealth or adventure.

This booklet is intended for dungeon masters. The two modules are for 1st-2nd level player characters. Descriptions of spells, monsters, traps, and rules can be found in Player's Handbook, Dungeon Master's Guide, Monster Manual, and Volo's Guide to Monsters. Having access to the Sword Coast Adventurer's Guide is also helpful.

The player characters have a chance at getting to know the city. No map of the city is provided. Feel free to use your map and add more non-player characters as you see fit and suit your playing style and your group of players.

HULBURG

Hulburg is a small city north of Moonsea. House Hulmaster built the Griffonwatch Keep there, and their descendants still act as regents over the city. Thar, known for their barbaric orc tribes and constant warfare, neighbors the city, which has proven problematic. Hulburg has an excellent natural harbor, protected by Keldon head and Easthead. North of the city stretches the Tharian moorlands, where many ancient barrows and desolate tombs can be found, rumored to be home of both treasures and undead alike. River Winterspear runs through the city and drains into the Moonsea.

Winters are long and hard. Even the harbor waters freeze over some winters, making the city inaccessible by sea. Summers are bright, the days are long, the hills are green, even great vibrant green, and dotted with grazing sheep and cattle. The Spellplague hit the area hard, and the locals claim that the strong green color of the grass is because of that.

The city is run by Natali Hulmaster, who took over as a harmach when she was 14. House Veruna had tried to seize control of the city in an elaborate plot (see below). The harmach controls the Shieldsworn, the city guards who maintain law and order.

Commerce and trade with wood, furs, iron, and silver dominate the city's economy. In recent years more and more artisans have moved to the city, and the population is growing, numbering almost seven thousand today. Merchants and artisans have formed guilds. The harmach does not interfere much with their businesses, as long as they share her vision and help her maintain the city's continued prosperity.

The people of Hulburg are not a religious lot. There are few churches but a few shrines dedicated to major deities, such as Lathander, Torm, and Umberlee. A small congregation, which consists only of women, is devoted to Shar, and now and then, rumors of secret cults worshiping Cyric or Bane frequent the taprooms and taverns of the city.

HISTORIC OVERVIEW

Founded in 940 DR, the Year of the Cold Claws, Hulburg became the seat of power for the Hulmaster family from Mulmaster. The city has been besieged repeatedly, ransacked, and left in ruins but always rebuilt. That is why many houses stand on old foundations, of houses long forgotten, and have deep cellars.

One of the most prominent kings of the area, Aesperus or the King in Copper, was related to the Hulmasters, but he ruled a kingdom in eastern Thar, where he practiced necromancy. He was deposed in a rebellion led by Lathander's clergy and his relative, Rivan Hulmaster. Upon his death, Aesperus transformed into a lich and held dominion over the undead in eastern Thar. He got his revenge when he summoned a hoard of undead and attacked the cities and towns of the northern Moonsea region. However, the lich struck a bargain with the Hulmasters and vowed not to harm the city.

In the Year of the Thunder, 1306 DR, Hulburg was left in ruins after a war against Mulmaster in the Moonsea Wars. Still, the people of Hulburg persisted and rebuilt once more. Forty years later, a massive orc hoard, aided by the forces of Zhentil Keep, attacked and left the city in utter ruins. For decades only a handful of people lived in Hulburg, but at the start of the 15th century, people started building the city once more.

In 1479 DR, the Merchant Guild, supported by House Veruna from Mulmaster, the Warlock Knights of Vaasa, and the shadowmage Rhovann Disarnnyl, tried to usurp power in Hulburg. After being besieged by orcs and set by other misfortunes, Rhovann became ruler for a brief time, but the Hulmasters, led by the Swordmage Geran Hulmaster, managed to become ruler to seize control again and throw house Veruna out of the city.

NOTABLE PLACES AND LAWS

Hulburg is divided by river Winterspear. East of the river, many buildings are still being rebuilt or are under construction. Many houses are empty. West of the river, things have moved faster, and people live in almost all houses, and there are many shops, inns, taverns, and workshops.

The Shieldsworn guard the city and maintain law and order. Guard captains and Tormite chaplains are responsible for investigations concerning the safety of the people, but the Hulmasters leave matters of mercantile and produce to the guilds. In some parts of the city, people have formed small militias to ensure safety. The guilds also have their guards, and each guild has its own rules as to how the guards are funded or supplied.

Murders and thefts are illegal, and murderers and thieves suffer harsh judgment. Only the harmach is allowed to collect taxes; however, many guilds have found ways around those laws, for example, by having their members pay annual fees and so on. Guilds and merchant houses cannot operate within the city limits without permission from the harmach.

GRIFFINWATCH KEEP

Griffinwatch Keep was built by the Hulmasters and stands on a steep hill west of Winterspear River with a great view over the city. The steep hills and high unscalable cliffs form a natural barrier on three sides and a powerful curtain wall on the fourth side. Shieldsworn man the castle wall and defend Natali, harmach of Hulburg.

Griffinwatch Keep is an ancient keep; the main building, where the Hulmasters live, has a mighty tower, surrounded by a square keep with a tower on each of the three other corners. The walls were built using rock from the hill where the keep stands. Inside the walls is a stable, smithy, and barracks of the Shieldsworn.

The Shieldsworn always have at least one company in the castle, consisting of **20 guards**, **1 knight**, and **1 priest**.

HARBOR

The Hulburg harbor is one of the liveliest places in the city during summer when many merchant ships from all over the Moonsea, and even some who sail north the River Lis, come. The locals also have many fishing boats and yachts. During winter, the waters in the harbor sometimes freeze over.

The harbor is naturally protected by Keldon head and Easthead. The harbor cove is deep and suits large ships and smaller vessels.

WHITEBRIDGE

Winterspear river is bridged in several places, though no bridge is as grand as Whitebridge, not far from Griffinwatch Keep. It is decorated with statues showing many prominent members of house Hulmasters. The bridge is one of the most famous landmarks in the city, and it is customary for newlyweds to walk across the bridge, as a simple of them crossing into a new chapter in their lives.

Not many people know that the bridge was designed so that the harmach could easily topple it. At the feet of the bridge are ancient magical sigils, which the harmach can activate, that weaken the bridge's structural integrity, making it fall into the Winterspear river. As more and more bridges have been built, these precautions are no longer necessary.

THE WILD HOG

The Wild Hog is a two-story inn not far from the harbor. The inn is run by the Carlson family, who came from Lurien. They are halflings and have rooms for small, medium, and large creatures.

Linda is the head of the Carlson family. She is determined and hard-headed; she seldom hesitates to use her club when the guests become too rowdy or impolite. Her hair is graying, and she tends to have a smile on her lips, even when brandishing her club. She knows Hulburg well and notes adventurers' activity in the city. When she was younger, she was an adventurer and a member of the Harpers. After her father retired, she left her adventuring days behind when she took over the Wild Hog, but Harpers know it is a safe house for them.

The Wild Hog's common room is popular among locals and travelers since it is lively, and bards entertain most nights. The common room can be found in the inn's cellar, and the Harpers' sign has been delicately carved into a post near the bar (if the player characters are actively looking for such sign, they spot it with a successful DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check).

Outside The Wild Hog is a large bulletin board, where both authorities and locals post their notices. Sometimes adventurers can find jobs or ideas for assignments there.

THE GRIFFIN & THE SWORD

This tavern was once among the most popular pubs in Hulburg, but once Hergor Blueax, a shield dwarf from Waterdeep, took over the bar a few years back, the place's popularity has been dwindling. The Griffin & The Sword stands in the hillside of the Griffinwatch Keep, with a great view of the harbor. In the summertime, the three balconies of the tavern were crowded, and guests enjoyed both good drinks and excellent food.

What Hergor doesn't know is that the local Zhentarim group uses the tavern as their base of operations, and they have been spreading rumors about the tavern, saying that people have become sick by eating the food and an elf woman was murdered on the top floor and has returned as a ghost to haunt the place.

The dwarf has done what he can to get more business, but it seems that all he does is in vain. Therefore he has set up a workshop in the basement where he sharpens knives, swords, and axes, to make up for his loss running The Griffin & The Sword.

THE BLACK ROSE

The Black Rose is a new tavern near Whitebridge, east of the Winterspear river. The Rose is run by a couple, Isobel and Vilia. They are both in their forties and good hostesses. They also have rooms to let, but only for women. The word on the street is that they offer sanctuary for women fleeing their violent husbands.

The Black Rose is a three-story stone building with a good view of the river. The common room is on ground level, the food is good, and they pride themselves in offering only excellent ale. In the summertime, bards and minstrels entertain guests. Very few know that Isobel and Vilia lead the Sisterhood, a small congregation of Shar worshippers. Only women are allowed in the cell, especially those that have experienced hardship at home.

NEW GATE

The city walls have been rebuilt in the last years and reinforced heavily. There are a few gates, and the most used one is New Gate, which leads north to Thar and further along the banks of Winterspear river.

The gate is large and provides enough space for two wagons, and during summer, this is a busy place. The gate is open from sunrise to sundown in that season, but Shieldsworn checks on merchant caravans and ensures no contraband is being hauled through the city. Frequent orc attacks have made the guards suspicious towards anyone who shares orcish ancestry, and many half-orcs have been forced to turn away and denied entry to the city. During winter, the gate is only open for a short while, around noon, but travelers can ring a bell and hope they can convince the Shieldsworn to open the gates for them.

New gate has two tall watchtowers and a guardhouse. The gate itself is twofold, the inner gate is made from oak bound with iron, but the outer gate is an iron portcullis, which is only dropped during sieges.

SARTH'S TOWER

The tiefling SARTH Khul Riizar is a powerful sorcerer and one of Geran Hulmaster's companions when Geran battled House Veruna and Rhovann's coup. For his help, SARTH was promoted to Master Mage of Hulburg.

SARTH's Tower is east of Winterspear River and can be found in the northernmost district. The population there has been slowly growing, and the tower is no longer as prominent as it once was. The four-story building is made from stone. SARTH uses the tower for his arcane research, but his living quarters are in a small house adjacent to the tower. Neither the tower nor the house is extravagant or noteworthy.

SARTH is hard to reach, as he is a very busy man, tending both to his matters and matters of Hulburg.

KELDON HEAD

To either side of the harbor, two prominent capes reach out into the Moonsea. The east one is called East Head, and the other is Keldon Head, which is over 600 feet high and offers a great view of the Moonsea. A watchtower, manned by Shieldsworn, stands at the top of the head.

The city reaches up the hills, but above the city level, the steep hill is woody, and there are shrines devoted to Silvanus and Mielikki. On Keldon head is also an ancient tomb. Youngsters in Hulburg play a game, forcing anyone turning 13 to spend a night in the tomb entrance, as some coming-of-age ritual. Shieldsworn have not stopped the children so far, but other people are not allowed to enter the tomb without the harmach's permission.

THE POTION-BREWER

The Potion-brewer is a short module for 4-6 1st level player characters. Playing through the module takes about 2-4 hours, and it should be pretty easy to modify encounters to suit smaller or larger groups.

Bertalamein Vesteins makes a living in Hulburg by brewing potions. When his cockatrice is stolen, he reaches out and asks the player characters to help him retrieve the beast.

BACKGROUND

Hulburg is growing, and Natali Hulmaster is a young and inexperienced hamarch. She has advisors, like her niece Kara Hulmaster and Sarth, but some look to Hulburg in envy and hatred.

One of those is Taila Veruna from Mulmaster. She is a part of the House Veruna trading company that once took part in a coup to seize control of Hulburg. A few tendays ago, Taila came to Hulburg, eager to enact revenge upon the Hulmasters and the defeat House Veruna suffered at the hands of Geran Hulmaster and his friends. House Veruna's leader sent her to reinstate the trading company's business alliances in Hulburg. Taila hired the goliath Grynd Darkhand, a renowned mercenary thug, and tasked him with making the lives of Hulburg's artisans and merchants difficult.

And that is what Grynd has been doing lately. He has visited many merchants, demanding that they pay a protection fee, left artisan workshops in ruins, blackmailed some, and been, to put it short, a menace to society. Grynd is hot-headed and a devoted follower of Bane. He has a gang of bandits called The Brotherhood of the Black Hand. Their headquarters are in an old house not far from the harbor, east side of Winterspear river. The house was once used to get ink from octopuses and other cephalopods. The members of the gang all dip their right hand into the old inkwells as a symbol of their membership.

Taila Veruna has set up a shop on the west side, where she sells equipment for adventurers under the name Sarah Teh. That way, she can keep an eye out for the comings and goings of adventurers without drawing any suspicion. She has also been building relationships within Hulburg's merchant guild.

The gnome Bertalamein Vesteins is one of the most prestigious potion-brewer in Hulburg. He constantly improves his potions and extracts and often hires adventurers to find some forlorn or strange ingredients. In his workshop, he keeps many live animals and beasts, one of them being cockatrice. Very few know, however, that Bertalamein is a devoted follower of Talona and is trying to create a poison that he can pour into the Winterspear river, to cause a massive outbreak of plague in Hulburg.

OVERVIEW

Grynd has taken Bertalamein's cockatrice. After denying to pay the protection fee Grynd demanded, Bertalamein suspected something might happen but was too preoccupied with his studies to do anything about it. The Brotherhood of the Black Hand broke into his workshop and stole his most prized beast, the cockatrice. Bertalamein reaches out to the player characters and asks them for help.

After speaking to other merchants and artisans in Hulburg, the player characters find out where the Brotherhood's hideout is. To save the cockatrice, they need to enter the old house and put an end to the Brotherhood of the Black Hand.

A PLEA FOR HELP

It is early spring in Hulburg. On the 25th day of Ches, the potion-brewer Bertalamein discovers that his cockatrice has gone missing. There are obvious signs of breaking, and he runs out to the street, looking for the strange monstrosity. By chance, the player characters are walking in the same street. Bertalamein's Potion Shop can be found on Small Street, one of the main shopping streets in Hulburg, west of Winterspear.

The shadows are getting longer, and the daylight is waning as you walk along Small Street. High above Griffinwatch Keep stands vigilant guard as shopkeepers and artisans prepare their shops for the end of the day.

Suddenly, a thin-looking gnome bursts into the streets, looking desperately around, then runs across the street to a fruit vendor and looks under their table. The gnome turns around, seemingly in distress, muttering to himself: "Where is it? Where is it?" If the player characters step up and ask the gnome what he is looking for, he stares at them for a moment before telling them that he has lost his cockatrice in a hushed voice. A cockatrice is not your average pet, and most people would balk at hearing such proclamations. He introduces himself, pointing out his store on the other side of the street. He believes someone broke into his workshop and took the creature, which he suspects will be used for more harm than good.

If the player characters offer to help him search for the cockatrice, he is sincerely thankful, but no matter how much they seek in Small Street and adjacent streets, the creature is nowhere to be found. If the player characters wish to see his workshop and where Bertalamein kept the creature, he shows them to a small workshop behind his store. There are many cages containing animals and small beasts, such as bats and toads. With a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Arcana) check, the player characters can tell that many of the animals are in one way or another part of spell components. One of the cages is open.

By investigating Bertalamein's workshop, the player characters can find out the following:

DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation): The player characters investigate the cage and see that thieves' tools were used to open the lock. Still, the cage must have been broken after the cockatrice had been removed, perhaps to derail any investigation.

DC 13 Wisdom (Perception): The glass was cut and removed in one of the windows.

DC 10 Intelligence (Nature): Outside, by the backdoor, is a fine footprint with wet sand in it. Tasting the sand reveals that the water is not salted, which indicates that whoever was there must have been close to the Winterspear river before entering the workshop.

DC 15 Wisdom (Survival): A faint trail leads to Small Street but disappears since it is high impossible to track anyone on such a crowded street.

The burglar was sent by Grynd, who is planning on blackmailing Bertalamein. The burglar, the water genasi **thug** Lio Dola, loves swimming in the Winterspear river. He swam across the river to get to Bertalamein's shop without being noticed.

Bertalamein begs the player characters to help him, telling them that the cockatrice is vital in his experiments. He is willing to pay each player characters 50 gp and a Potion of Healing. With a successful DC 12 Charisma (Persuasion) check, he raises his offer to two Potions of Healing.

If the player characters ask Bertalamein if he suspects who might have taken the cockatrice, he tells the player characters that shady-looking men led by a goliath have been shaking down on the local merchants, demanding protection fee. Bertalamein didn't want to pay them; then the men threatened that he would regret not paying the fee. On the other hand, ever since this happened, almost two tendays ago, he hasn't seen any of these men.

STREETS OF HULBURG

By speaking with other merchants and people of Hulburg, the player characters can discover what Grynd and his comrades have been up to and discover where their hideout is. This is an excellent chance for the player characters to get to know Hulburg and its people. The player characters can go all over the city and investigate the Brotherhood of the Black Hand. There are many rumors, both true and false, to hear, but once the player characters have pieced together the clues, they should be aware of the gang's hideout.

The following locals all have either encountered the Brotherhood of the Black Hand or know someone that has. The player characters must filter truth from fiction since the locals do not know what is true and what is not. Feel free to add more locals as you see fit and suit your playing style.

ARON IRONHEART — APPRENTICE TO BRAND IRONHEART, THE BLACKSMITH

The gold dwarf Aron Ironheart is an apprentice and son (in that order) of Hulburg's most proficient blacksmith, Brand Ironheart. Aron has strived to pick up his father's trade, but in his heart, he longs more for becoming a bard and seeing the world. He is keen on learning about the player characters and keeps asking about their adventures, and if the player characters share some of their stories, whether true or false, he is even more willing to share what he knows with them.

Aron is a young dwarf, only 40 years old, and became his father's apprentice a few years ago. His hair and beard are dark, his eyes hazel and filled with romance and lust for adventure. Brand, however, is about as charismatic as a light post and has no time for a frivolous chat with people who have no intention of buying his wares.

If the player characters ask about Grynd or the Brotherhood, Aron tells them the following:

- The goliath has many thugs and villains, and Aron has heard that they have been linked with the infamous Zhentarim, who are trying to take over the city. **(False)**
- He once heard a man come to his father, claiming to be a part of a group called Brotherhood of the Black Hand. Aron caught a glimpse of the man and saw that his fingers were blackened. **(True)**

DORA HANSIGNE

Dora is in her sixties and has lived in Hulburg her whole life. She knows the city's history and can answer the player characters' questions about such matters. Dora is a seamstress, and among her clients is Sarth, something which she takes great pride in.

Dora is grey-haired and hunched. Her fingers are gnarly, and her eyes are piercing, like the needles in her needle pillow. She has a way with words, and her words can sting. The locals respect her, but she is loved by the children, who come every day to her workshop to help her and listen to her stories. To many of them, she has the role of a granny.

Dora has paid the Brotherhood a protection fee of 2 gp per month. She is old, and no one is eager to help her stand up to these thugs. She says that Sarth hasn't been around lately, and the Shieldsworn are useless to do anything safe for strutting around like they own the city. Her guild is powerless and has no chance of standing up to Grynd and his thugs. If asked about the Brotherhood, she shakes her head and curses these ruffians, saying that it is evident that their parents failed miserably. She shares the following information with the player characters:

- Their leader is a goliath called Grynd. Dora suspects that he is a very misinformed man, for she saw him bearing a necklace with the holy symbol of Bane. **(True)**
- Grynd told her that the Brotherhood has all sorts of monstrosities in their midst, gargoyles among them who are tasked with watching the streets. **(False)**

ELDAR IL'HALA – SHIELDSWORN

Eldar recently joined the Shieldsworn and is rather pleased with himself because of this. Eldar is a dark-haired half-elf who grew up on one of the outlying farms in Winterspear valley. He is afraid that his humble background might somehow come back to haunt him, which is why he tends to exaggerate his importance as a Shieldsworn. He has been tasked with keeping an eye on the guilds.

Eldar has heard a thing or two about the Brotherhood, though he has never met any of them. He can tell the player characters the following:

- The Brotherhood began shaking down the merchants on the east side of Winterspear river. **(True)**
- The leader of the Brotherhood is a powerful sorcerer, using the money earned from the protection fee, to finance their search for the tomb of the King in Copper. **(False)**

With a DC 15 Intelligence (History) check, the player characters know that the King in Copper was once a king in this region who mastered necromancy.

FENN ODAL – LEADER OF THE BAKER'S GUILD

Fenn Odal is an Illuskan, fifty years old and bold. He is a large man, both horizontal and vertical. His arms are like tree trunks. He is the leader of the Baker's Guild and enjoys this responsibility greatly. Still, he is righteous, and one of his main agendas is to ensure that the people of Hulburg have can always afford bread.

Though members of the guild have been visited by the Brotherhood, Grynd has yet to set his gang up against the leaders of the guilds. Fenn has heard from other bakers the demands of the Brotherhood. Fenn can tell the player characters the following:

- This group of thugs are mostly newcomers and have claimed one of the abandoned buildings on the east side as their own. **(True)**
- Only men are allowed to join the Brotherhood. They abuse women and rape them; many women have stayed at Isobel and Vilia. **(False)**

HALLDOR HORTHAR – HARBOR MASTER

Halldor is one of the few half-orcs in Hulburg, and he has been harbormaster for almost a decade. At first glance, he might seem human, but his yellow eyes and canine teeth betray him. Halldor has never spent any time among orcs as he grew up in Shadowdale and was an adventurer for many years. He can still hold his own in combat, though he avoids such encounters.

Halldor has seen the members of the Brotherhood and heard much about them. The Brotherhood has kept away from the harbor area, save for using the old ink factory as their hideout. Halldor has seen gang members around the house but has not seen any reason to interfere since they leave the ships and related businesses alone.

Halldor can tell the player characters the following:

- The Brotherhood is under the protection of some member of house Hulmaster, and the Shieldsworn have been ordered to leave them be. **(False)**
- Some people have been seen around the old ink factory, and some of the dockhands say that they are forbidden to go there. **(True)**

LINDA KARLSON – OWNER OF THE WILD HOG

Linda is a joyful halfling who enjoys greatly running the inn and tavern The Wild Hog. She loves meeting new people and takes great pride in the food she serves. She has brown, quick eyes, and can spot trouble from a mile, after years of adventuring with members of the Harpers. As the story goes, people used to say that there wasn't a house in Sembia that could keep her out (with a successful DC 12 Intelligence (History) check the player characters have heard about Linda).

The Brotherhood has visited her and demanded a protection fee. She showed them her club, and they fled with the tail between their legs. Since then, someone has unsuccessfully tried to set the Wild Hog afire, but she and her family managed to douse the flames.

Linda can tell the player characters the following:

- Amongst the members of the Brotherhood are gnomes and tieflings. This gang is diverse and not just a bunch of unfortunates. **(True)**
- The Brotherhood has connections with the ruling elite in Hulburg. **(False)**

HERGOR BLUEAX – THE OWNER OF THE GRIFFIN & THE SWORD

The shield dwarf Hergor Blueax, once a mighty and proud warrior, is depressed and miserable. He no longer braids his beard and gets easily annoyed. The reason is simple, his tavern, The Griffin & The Shield, which he hoped he would make good money from, is not going well, and he doesn't know why (see above). Hergor is muscular and strong, his hair is red, and his eyes are green. Hergor uses a wheelchair, after he suffered a grievous wound fighting a hill giant.

The Brotherhood collects a protection fee from Hergor, which has not improved his mood. He is convinced that his troubles can be blamed on the Brotherhood, so he hates them. Still, he has not found the strength to refuse to pay up when the gang members visit him.

Hergor can tell the player characters the following:

- The person who collects the Brotherhood fee, Vigor (see below), always comes after sunset but never enters the tavern, making Hergor believe that Vigor is a vampire. **(False)**
- Vigor has a funny, salty smell, but Hergor doesn't know why. **(True)**

ISOBEL AND VILIA – THE OWNERS OF THE BLACK ROSE

The couple, Isobel and Vilia, are leaders of a small secret and all-female congregation worshipping Shar. The cult has been active in Hulburg for more than a century. Both women, who are in their forties, also run the tavern the Black Rose, serving good food and excellent ale.

They have heard much about the Brotherhood but have yet to have some of the ruffians visit them. So far, they haven't heard that the members abuse women, but they can tell the player characters the following:

- The Brotherhood of the Black Hand has no interest in the working ladies of Hulburg and leave them completely alone. **(False)**
- Members of the Brotherhood seem to have dyed their hands black. **(True)**

KARA HULMASTER – ADVISOR TO NATALI HULMASTER

Kara is a striking woman in her thirties, with azure fire in her eyes and a blue spellscar after being touched by the Spellplague. She usually wears fine leather armor. Kara has heard about the Brotherhood, but she hasn't seen anything to make her believe that the guilds should deal with this gang.

Kara is interested in the player characters and asks them many questions. With a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check, the player character sense that she is trying to learn more about them to see if they would be good candidates if she ever needs help.

Kara can tell the player characters the following:

- Grynd is a goliath who came recently from Mulmaster. **(True)**
- The Brotherhood is just a gang of ruffians that the guild will take care of, sooner or later. **(False)**

TALIA VERUNA (SARAH TEH) – OWNER OF TEH'S BAAZAR

Talia opened her shop earlier this winter and has offered her wares to adventurers and travelers. She is all smiles and charismatic, her auburn hair is flowing, and she wears open-neck blouses. Her charm allows her to keep her prizes up, and she never offers any discounts. She is very interested in her customers and asks many questions. With a successful DC 18 Wisdom (Insight) check, the player characters feel there's something more to her.

Talia tells the player characters the following:

- The Brotherhood is nothing more than a few unfortunate local men trying to get recognition. **(False)**
- She has heard that these men often gather on the third floor of The Griffin & the Sword. **(False)**

THE HIDEOUT

The ink factory was a successful business before the siege of the orcs from Thar, just after the Hulmasters managed to defeat Rhowann. After the siege, the owners decided to close and move to Raven's Bluff. Today the factory is a hideout for the Brotherhood of the Black Hand. They have strung black curtains over windows and kept their activity there as secret as possible.

When the player characters have pieced together the clues, they should have figured out that the hideout is most likely found in the old ink factory. If the player characters have not taken any precautions to ensure that people do not tell anyone they are looking for the Brotherhood, the gang becomes aware of this. It takes precautions, setting someone on the lookout and having active traps in their lair. If there's someone on the watch, with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, the player characters spot someone hiding in one of the windows on the third floor.

The old ink factory is not far from the harbor, east of Winterspear river. It is a three-story building, the lowest level made from stone but the higher levels wood. All glasses in windows are broken, and at first glance, it seems like no one has cared or entered the house for years. It has a slate roof with slates of red stone, many of which have become loose and fallen to the ground.

The Brotherhood hides inside if the lookout sees or the gang becomes aware of the player characters, waiting in an ambush on the 2nd floor. Grynd commands his comrades to leave no one alive. If the player characters surprise the Brotherhood, its members are in their rooms, unsuspecting that the player characters are coming. However, soon as someone becomes aware of the player characters, they immediately warn the other members by calling out.

HIDEOUT FEATURES

The following features are common to all areas of the barrow unless otherwise noted. One square on the map (see below) equals 5 feet.

Walls and Floors. Walls and floors on the ground floor are worked stone; on upper floors, walls and floors are made of wood.

Doors. All doors are made from wood. Each door is nondescript and rotten. Unless otherwise noted, all doors are unlocked and can be opened with a DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check. All doors have AC 15 and 30 hit points (damage threshold 5).

Light. All areas of the hideout are dimly lit.

1. FOYER

The foyer is dark and looks like no one has been in the house for years. There are two fake doors in the otherwise empty foyer. There however two secret doors, one leads into the old factory office and the other one into the workroom.

Doors. Both doors are fake and simply fastened to the walls. If someone tries to open the doors, they fall to the floor with enough noise to alert anyone in the house. With a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check, the player characters can tell that the doors are fake.

Secret doors. With a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, the player characters spot the secret doors.

2. WORKROOM

In this room workers used to drain ink from octopuses and cephalopods. The ink was gathered in large barrels and mixed with water. The ink has almost dried, except in one barrel, where it has turned into a thick black liquid. Touching it leaves a black stain which is hard to wash off. The ink has a strong and salty odor. Grynd has forced all members of the Brotherhood to dip their hand into the ink, to mark them as full members of the gang. The Brotherhood also uses this room to store non-valuable items, such as rations, backpacks, and so on. In the furthest corner of the room, the player characters spot bloodstains on the floor, where the Brotherhood has interrogated and tortured their enemies.

3. OFFICE

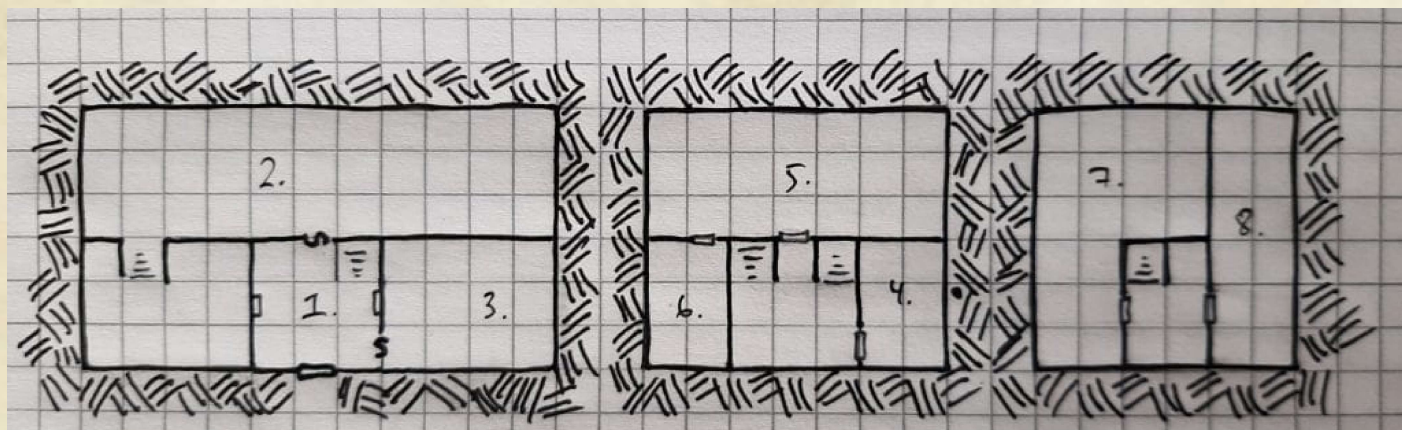
What was once the factory office, is now no more than an elaborate trap. In one corner of the room is a new, large chest and a couple of gold coins in front of it, to have anyone believe the chest is filled with treasure.

Trap. In front of the chest is a hidden pit (see DMG p. 122), which is 20 feet deep. Anyone falling into the pit makes enough noise to alert anyone in the house of intruders.

Chest. The chest is unlocked but empty. The two gold coins in front of the chest are real though.

4. KITCHEN

The kitchen is small and only has one fireplace, a barrel of water, and a locker, containing food and rations for 20 days.



1. FLOOR

2. FLOOR

3. FLOOR

5. MEMBER'S QUARTERS

Four members of the Brotherhood share this room, the male water genasi **thug** Lio Dola, and **3 bandits**, the female tiefling Ular, the male half-elf Dorn, and the male halfling Mouser. There are two bunks and a chest by either bunkbed. If the members have become aware of the player characters, they set up an ambush by the door.

Chests. Both chests are locked and can be opened with thieves' tools and a DC 15 Dexterity check. All those that live in this room have keys to the locks. One of the chests contains 36 gold coins and a Potion of Invisibility, but the other has 42 gold coins and an onyx necklace, which has the holy symbol of Shar (taken from one of the women who are part of the Shar cult in Hulburg).

Tactics. If the player characters surprise the group, they call for assistance from Grynd and Vigor. If the group knows the player characters, they set up an ambush by the door and take out spellcasters first.

6. BANE SHRINE

This small room has a shrine dedicated to Bane. The shrine is small and has a small statue depicting a black gauntlet. Here Grynd prays to Bane and compels the rest of the Brotherhood to do so. There's a faint salty sea odor in the room.

Shrine. The statue is made of wood but dipped in the ink downstairs. The player characters discover this with a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check. The player characters recognize Bane's holy symbol with a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Religion) check. Beneath the statue, there's a small hole in the altar, where members of the Brotherhood have made their donations or sacrifices to Bane. Inside the shrine are 13 sp, one gp, and a silver ring with a small bloodstone worth 25 gp. Good-aligned player characters might gain inspiration for destroying the shrine.

7. GRYND'S ROOM

This room is in utter chaos. Grynd, goliath **bandit leader**, is not bothered by keeping this room tidy. In one corner is what might be considered a bed but other parts of the room are in such disarray it is nigh impossible to figure out what purpose they serve. Investigating the room reveals an assortment of knives, daggers, short swords, a great axe, and a locked chest. All the junk in the room makes the floor difficult terrain. The cockatrice is in a cage in the furthest corner.

Chest. The chest is locked and trapped with a poison needle (see DMG p. 123). The lock can be opened with thieves' tools and a successful DC 15 Dexterity check. Grynd has a key to the lock in his pocket. The chest contains a leather pouch with 180 gp, two Potions of Healing, and Eyes of the Eagle.

Cockatrice. While in the cage, the cockatrice is not troublesome. If let out of the cage, it runs amok, biting any creature approaching it.

8. VIGOR'S ROOM

Vigor is Grynd's right-hand man but very eager to betray the goliath to claim the Brotherhood for himself. Vigor has white hair and is very pale, his eyes are red, and he avoids sunlight at all costs. Many people believe that he is a vampire, he is not, but he likes it that way. He is a devout Banite and a human **cult fanatic**. His room is organized and tidy. He has a locked cabinet where he keeps his valuables.

Tactics. If Vigor hears the player characters fighting Grynd, he doesn't help the bandit leader. He waits and hopes that the player characters will somehow kill or capture the goliath, leaving him in charge of the Brotherhood. If the player characters attack him, he will use Hold Person on whoever is the most threatening combatant before calling out to Grynd. If the player characters find him after defeating Grynd, he will try and persuade them to let him go; if they do, he will make a deal with Talia to take over the Brotherhood and continue shaking down the merchants Hulburg.

Cabinet. The unlocked cabinet holds 56 gp and Gloves of Thievery in a secret compartment, which the player characters can find with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check.

CONCLUSION

If the player characters find the cockatrice and return it to Bertalamein, he is very thankful and offers them a 20% discount on all potions in the future. Suppose the player characters put an end to the Brotherhood. In that case, the merchants of Hulburg become aware of their heroic actions, and for a month, the player characters have an advantage on Charisma ability checks, as long as they keep up their heroic work.

CHILD'S PLAY

Child's play suits a group of 4-6 2nd level player characters. Playing through the modules takes 2-4 hours, and it can easily be modified to fit a larger or smaller group.

When Wilfred doesn't return home one night, his mother, Linda, reaches out to the player characters. Wilfred visited the tomb on Keldon Head but hasn't been seen since. Can the player characters find the boy and bring him back safe and sound?

ADVENTURE BACKGROUND

The tomb of Keldon Head is ancient. Many bards and sages have theorized about the origin of the tomb, but the fact is that it was built by the King in Copper for his son, Aetrus, after the latter fell fighting an orc horde from Thar. Many treasures were laid in the tomb with the prince, the Copper shield among them.

Wilfred is the youngest son to Linda Karlson, the inn The Wild Hog owner, and her husband, Oma'er. The teens of Hulburg play a game, as some coming-of-age ritual; they must spend a night in the tomb. For most, this is easily solved since fear prevents them from investigating the tomb, and they simply wait out the allotted time, praying to the gods nothing terrible will happen. Wilfred, however, is a halfling and has a nose for adventures, like his mother. He decided to have a look at the tomb and discovered a secret door, which he even managed to open. Unfortunately, the door closed behind him, and to make matters worse; he quickly found out that he wasn't alone and decided to hide.

The secret doors were enchanted; Aetrus and his knights would rise and attack the intruder if anyone opened the door. Aetrus was embalmed and wrapped in linen post-mortem and rose as a mummy, but his knights rose as skeletons.

OVERVIEW

When Linda discovers that Wilfred hasn't returned home one night, she reaches out to the player characters and asks them to help her look for him. She suspects that he might have gone to the tomb, for she knows this local ritual as most people of Hulburg do. Wilfred is the right age and has been asking questions about the tomb lately.

When the player characters reach the tomb, they discover the secret doors and find that skeletons have risen to fight off any intruder inside the tomb. A royal grave is at the other end of the tomb, where a mummy has risen.

Wilfred managed to hide in a small secret cell close to the royal grave, and once he sees the player characters, he rushes out to meet them. Linda is very thankful if the player characters bring him back safe and sound. If the player characters can defeat the mummy, they could earn themselves a magical shield.

THE LOST BOY

Early morning, on the 4th of Tarsakh, Linda summons the player characters to find her in The Wild Hog, whether they are guests or not. Linda, despite no longer being an active member of the Harpers, is well connected and knows what is going on in Hulburg. If the player characters rooted out the Brotherhood of the Black Hand, she has been watching their progress. If not, she has heard about the player characters and their other exploits.

When the player characters arrive, they find Linda in tears and desperate. She is upset and her husband, Oma'er, is trying to calm her down. The player characters sense that something has happened, with a successful DC 5 Wisdom (Insight) check.

Linda explains that her son, Wilfred, wasn't in his bed this morning. He must have sneaked out last night but hasn't returned home. She suspects that he has gone to take part in the youngsters' ritual, which she calls stupid. Wilfred had been asking many questions about the tomb these last few days, but she had been busy with running the tavern, she hadn't connected the dots until now. She knows that the tomb is somewhere up on Keldon Head but she has never bothered to go and look for it.

If asked about Wilfred, Linda says that he is very curious and adventurous, even more so than other halflings his age. He is smart and does seem to have a way of getting both in and out of trouble unharmed.

Linda asks the player characters to help them find Wilfred and make sure he returns safe and sound. If the player characters ask for payment, Linda shakes her head disappointed and says she expected more from heroes than be bothered with monetary gains when the life of a child is at a risk. If any of the player characters is a member of the Harpers, Linda shows them her pin and points out that being a part of this organization is helping each other out. If any of the player characters show interest in joining the Harpers, she will iterate that point.

The player characters know that Linda is a prominent citizen of Hulburg and among those that have helped the Hulmasters to rebuild the city, with a successful DC 10 Intelligence (History) check. The word is, that she tends to reward greatly those that go out of their way to make Hulburg a better place, though she might not always reward these people with gold pieces.

With a successful DC 12 Wisdom (Insight) check, the player characters sense that Linda loathes leaving the life of her son in the hands of some mercenaries, but she always remembers those that have helped her.

If the player characters refuse to help her unless they get paid, she sighs and thanks them for at least hearing her out. She will find some other people to help her find Wilfred. His body is found the next day if the player characters do not help Linda, something she never forgets.

THE YOUNGSTERS

If the player characters want to see if the youngsters in Hulburg know where to find Wilfred, they are easy to find. The youngsters in Hulburg tend to gather by Whitebridge and are led by Fil, a 15-year-old human boy. They are not very talkative to strangers and at first act like they have no idea who Wilfred is. With a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, the player characters notice that one of the youngsters, the female half-elf Diana, is flustered and upset; she avoids making eye contact with any of the player characters. If the player characters speak to her, with a successful DC 10 Charisma ability check, she says Fil sent her and Wilfred into the tomb on Keldon Head last night. They did as they were told and waited inside the tomb till midnight, but Wilfred wanted to explore the tomb. He was doing something deep in the tomb when she heard a strange grinding sound, then a rotting stench filled the tomb, and Wilfred was gone. This was too much for her, so she ran away. She fears for Wilfred and she wanted to tell her parents, but Fil told her not to.

If the player characters speak to Fil, he isn't keen on talking to them, even if the player characters spoke to Diana. With a successful DC 12 Charisma ability check, he admits to commanding Wilfred and Diana to spend the night in the tomb but says they were only supposed to be there until midnight. He doesn't want any trouble. If the player characters mention speaking to his parents, he becomes flustered and more eager to tell the player characters what happened. With a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check, the player characters feel that his situation at home isn't as good as it could be. If pressed, he admits that he told the kids to spend the night in the tomb but left early for he needed to help his father back home from The Griffin & the Sword, where he spends his night drinking. Though Fil never mentions it, it is evident that his father is abusive. If the player characters get directions from the youngsters or the kids guide them to the tomb, the walk there takes half an hour.

KELDON HEAD

Birch grows wild on Keldon Head, and there, in small clearings, are shrines dedicated to Mielikki and Sylvanus. This area is popular among the locals, and the Shieldsworn have a watchtower at the top, where they have a great view of the Moonsea and Hulburg's harbor. There are a few marked paths in the small woodland.

Looking for trails or footprints is almost impossible. With a successful DC 22 Wisdom (Survival) check, the player characters spot a trail left by small feet leading into the wooded area. Following this trail leads the player characters to the tomb.

Looking for the tomb is time-consuming. The player characters must make three successful checks; each check represents an hour of searching and investigating the area.

DC 15 Wisdom (Perception): The player characters spot an old, overgrown path leading to the west side of the head.

DC 12 Intelligence (Nature): The player characters discover an old quarry on the south side of the head. The rocks were masterfully hewn, probably by excellent masons. If there's a dwarf in the party, with a successful DC 15 Intelligence (History) check, they notice that dwarves must have cut the rocks, and the stones were transported west since the quarry is aligned that way.

DC 16 Intelligence (History): By recounting the story about the King of Copper's son, the player character figure out that the tomb was placed somewhere where it had a good view of the Moonsea because prince Aetrus loved the sea.

AETRUS' TOMB

The tomb is not easy to find, but the youngsters know where to find it. Built more than 400 years ago, it was carved into the side of Keldon Head and the entrance made from rocks from the quarry. Before Wilfred discovered the secret door, the locals believed the entrance room to be the tomb.

TOMB FEATURES

The tomb has the following features. One square on the map equals 10 feet.

Light. Save for the entrance, the tomb is dark.

Floor and Walls. All floors and walls are made from worked stone. With a successful DC 15 Stonecunning check, the player characters can see that the stonemasons must have been dwarven.

Doors. All doors are made from rotten wood and unlocked unless otherwise noted.

1. ENTRANCE

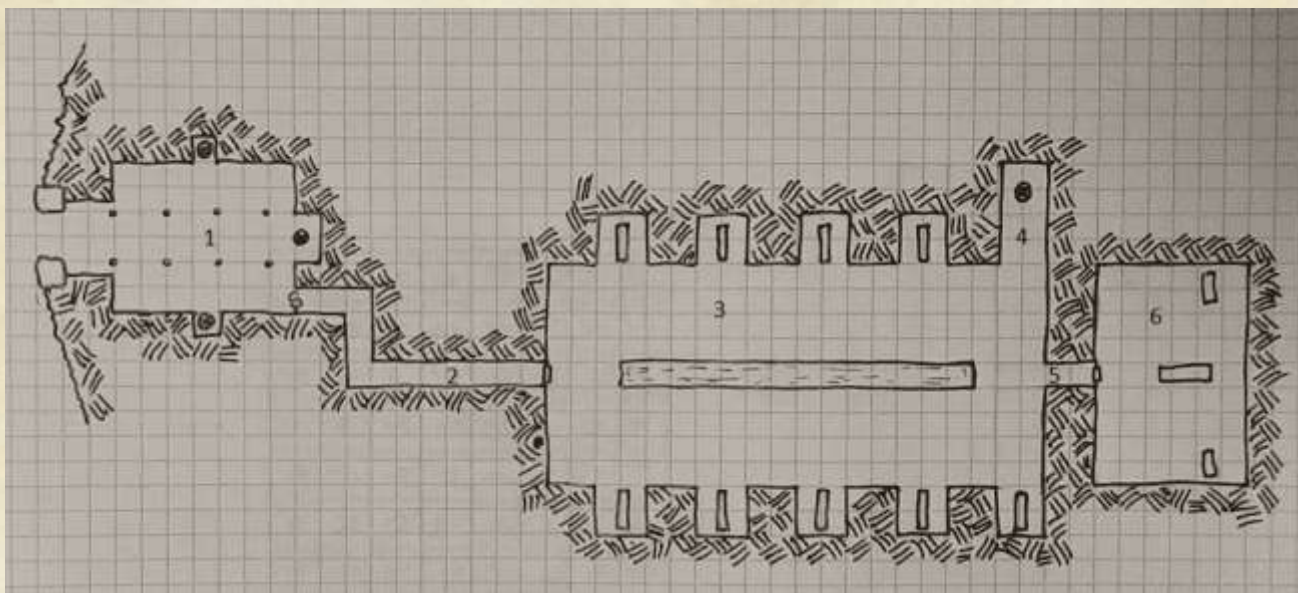
The entrance is large and was once decorated with rich tapestries, statues, and murals, though these have all lost color through the years. Outside the entrance are benches, once offering a beautiful view of the Moonsea; now, tall trees surround the tomb.

Wine and moss cover the entrance to what once was a beautiful and detailed tomb. Outside the entrance are two stone benches facing south, and it is easy to imagine the view it was offered of the Moonsea, but now tall trees block the view all around the tomb. Inside, the air is cool. The floor is laid with stone tiles. Marvelous and detailed statues show the same young man in different postures and roles. The walls are decorated with murals, once they must have been colorful, but all color has faded as years have passed.

There's not much traffic near or in the tomb since the Shieldsworn do not want people to disturb it. Finding the secret door is not as difficult now that Wilfred has found it and managed to open it. With a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check, the player characters spot the outlines of the secret door since the lines are no longer covered with dust and moss.

Statues and Murals. The player characters recognize the young man as Aetrus with a successful DC 15 Intelligence (History) check.

Secret door. To open the secret door, the player characters must find the mechanism to unlock them. One of the stone tiles has a pressure mechanism. With a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, the player characters find a small tile where the floor meets the wall. By pressing it, the doors unlock and swing open. If the player characters wish to break down the door, they can with a successful DC 25 Strength (Athletics) check.



2. PATH OF THE PRINCE

Inside the secret door is a long hallway, gradually leading down and deeper into the earth. The floor is laid with tiles. Halfway through the long hallway, the floor levels out. Dwarven runes (see *Sword Coast Adventurer's Guide* p. 105) have been etched on each tile (see Image 2 on p. 18).

The hallway leads you deep into the ground. As you press on, you stop as you see the tiles on the floor have changed. Each tile in front of you is now marked with a single dwarven rune, each tile with a different rune. What makes this even more interesting is that all the runes turn upside-down. At the other end of the hall are wooden doors.

Trap. The floor activates only on the other side, but each row is a carefully laid out magical trap. The dwarves that built the tomb made this trap to ensure, if ever the dead rose as undead, they would not find it easy to escape the tomb. With a successful DC 14 Intelligence (Arcana) check, the player characters spot small arcane glyphs of warding linked to each row of tiles with runes on. However, what makes this strange, is that all the runes are upside down when the player characters enter the tomb but face the right way when they leave the tomb. Only by stepping on the tiles that form the name of Aetrus the player characters can escape without harm (see picture). The trap doesn't trigger when the player characters enter the tomb. However, they can trigger the trap when they try to leave by stepping on the wrong tile.

Bypassing the Trap. The ceiling is 10 feet high, making jumping across the tiles difficult, but by making a successful Strength (Athletics) check, followed by a DC 10 Dexterity (Athletics) check, the player characters pass the traps without harm.

Activating the Trap. A creature stepping on the wrong tile is hit by the following spells (spell attack bonus +5, Spell save DC 13).

1. **Row:** Firebolt
2. **Row:** Acid Splash
3. **Row:** Ray of Frost
4. **Row:** Burning Hands
5. **Row:** Magic Missile

6. **Row:** Burning Hands

7. **Row:** Thunderwave. A creature pushed back, also triggers the glyphs in the row where they end, if the glyph hasn't been triggered yet.

8. **Row:** Sleep

Doors. The doors are unlocked.

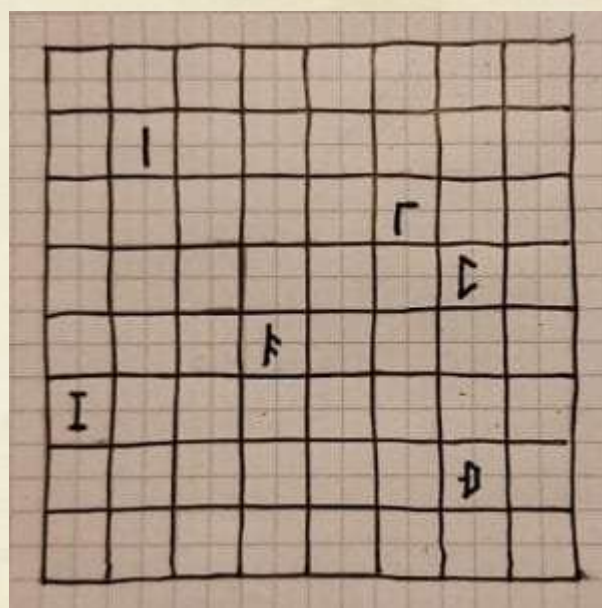


Image 1: The Correct Tiles

3. THE KNIGHT'S VAULT

The knight's vault is large, and on either side are decorated coffins, 7 of them are open, 2 closed. At the other end is the entrance leading to Myrkul's Hall and Aetrus' tomb. In the middle of the vault is a long pool; the water is stagnant and foul. A secret room, with memorial shrine dedicated to Aetrus, is also at the other end, **7 skeletons** stand there, all skeletons are headless. Once the player characters come closer, the skeletons move to attack.

Water. A creature drinking from the pool must make a DC 15 Constitution saving throw. The creature takes 1d6 poison damage on a failure and becomes poisoned for 1 hour.

Coffins. In each coffin are two gold coins pressed with the holy symbol of Myrkul. With a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Religion) check, the player characters know the Lord of Bones, once the god of the dead, but was killed during the Times of Troubles. Two coffins are still closed; with a successful DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check, the player characters open the coffins. Inside each is a **skeleton**, who attacks the nearest creature.

Wilfred. If the player characters defeat the skeleton, Wilfred comes rushing. He is terrified and tells the player characters that he barely escaped into the small secret room he discovered, but seemingly the skeletons couldn't follow him into the room. He is thirsty and hungry and tells the player characters that he would have tried to make a run for it if they wouldn't have come.

Once the player characters have found Wilfred, there's no need to investigate the tomb further. However, curiosity or greed might push the player characters to move on and explore the rest. If they do, Wilfred keeps back and hides if there's combat. If the player characters defeat the mummy in Aetrus' tomb, he will tell all his friends that he took part in the combat and how brave the player characters were.

4. THE MEMORIAL SHRINE

This secret room has a marble statue, showing Aetrus wearing chain mail and holding a shield and spear. Beneath the statue is an urn, where people once placed their memorial tokens but emptied the urn. Wilfred spotted three gemstones in the urn, which he took.

Gemstones. There were three stones, two red bloodstones, and one jade. The bloodstones are worth ten gp each, but the jade is worth 50 gp.

Statue. The player characters discover with a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check that the shield isn't made from marble but painted white. The shield was once Aetrus' shield and is a magical +1 shield.

5. MYRKUL'S HALL

This short hallway leads to a door made from green metal. On the right wall are nine strange triangular alcoves. Below the alcoves are nine skulls.

Doors. The player characters know that the heavy double doors are made from copper with a successful DC 10 Intelligence check. The doors are locked and can only be opened by solving the puzzle. The doors are guarded with Glyphs of Warding.

Puzzle. The small alcoves are in a varied triangular shape (see Image 3). Only by placing a skull inside the triangular alcoves that point up, like the holy symbol of Myrkul, the copper door unlocks with a clicking sound. If the player characters found any of the gold coins in the coffins, they have a helpful lead.

A trap is triggered if the skulls are put inside the alcoves in any other form. The trap has a +5 spell attack and DC 13 spell save.

Skulls in all downward facing alcoves: A click comes from the door. A skeletal hand forms and touches the creature if a creature touches the door, like the spell Chill Touch.

Skulls in all alcoves pointing at the door: A click comes from the door. A creature touching the door is hit with the spell Inflict Wounds.

Skulls in all alcoves: A ghostly skull forms in the door. Any creature within 15 feet is hit with the spell Cause Fear.

6. AETRUS' TOMB

The tomb is decorated and lavish. In the middle of the room is a beautiful sarcophagus. At the other end are chests, urns, and barrels holding the prince's items in life. Soon as anyone enters the room, the sarcophagus opens, and a **mummy** rises from it and attacks all living creatures in the tomb. **Treasures.** The chests, barrels, and urns hold items that Aetrus had in life, most of which are ruined. Rummaging through the stuff, the player characters discover a golden vase, decorated with obsidian, worth 250 gold coins. In one of the chests are 5000 cp.

Sarcophagus. Inside the sarcophagus is a silver and gold crown worth 2000 gp. Engraved in gold is the Hulmaster family crest. If the player characters return the crown to Natali or Kara Hulmaster, they are very grateful and will pay the player characters 200 gp each and a brooch which marks the player characters as friends of Hulburg.

CONCLUSION

If the player characters return Wilfred to Linda alive and unharmed, she is ecstatic and offers them to stay at The Wild Hog for free while they are in Hulburg. If the player characters have the crown, she urges them to return it to the Hulmasters. If the player characters do and receive the brooch; while wearing it in Hulburg, they gain an advantage to Charisma ability checks when dealing with the Shieldsworn.

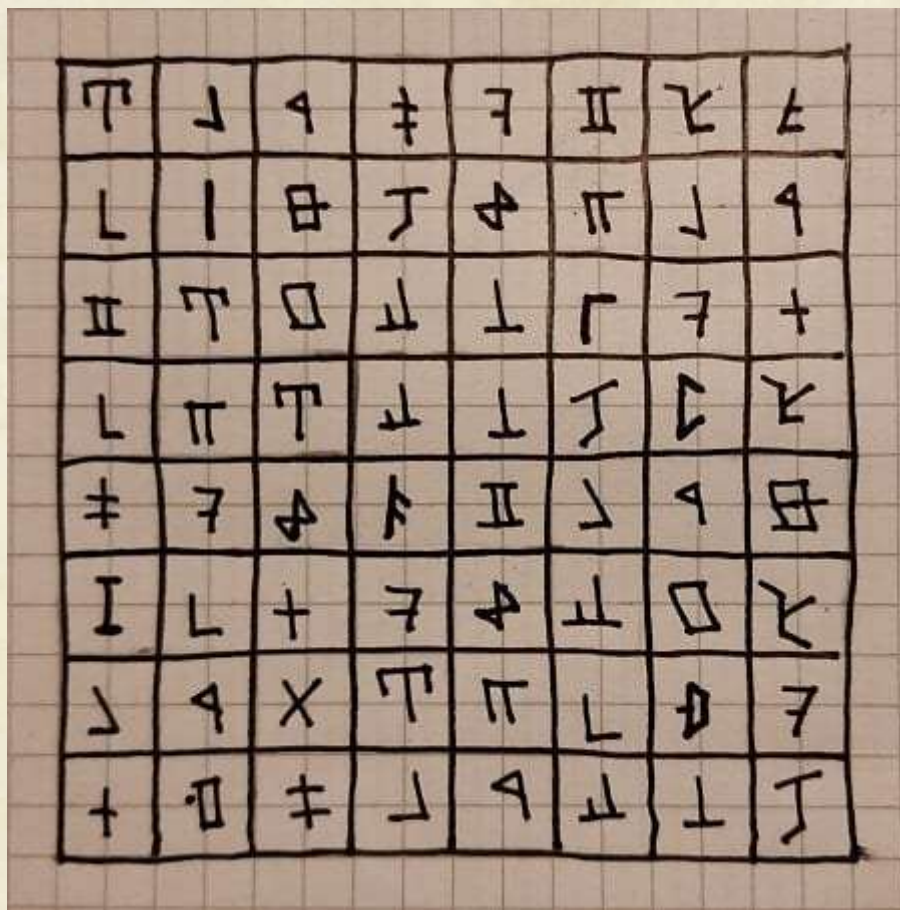


Image 2: The Path of the Prince

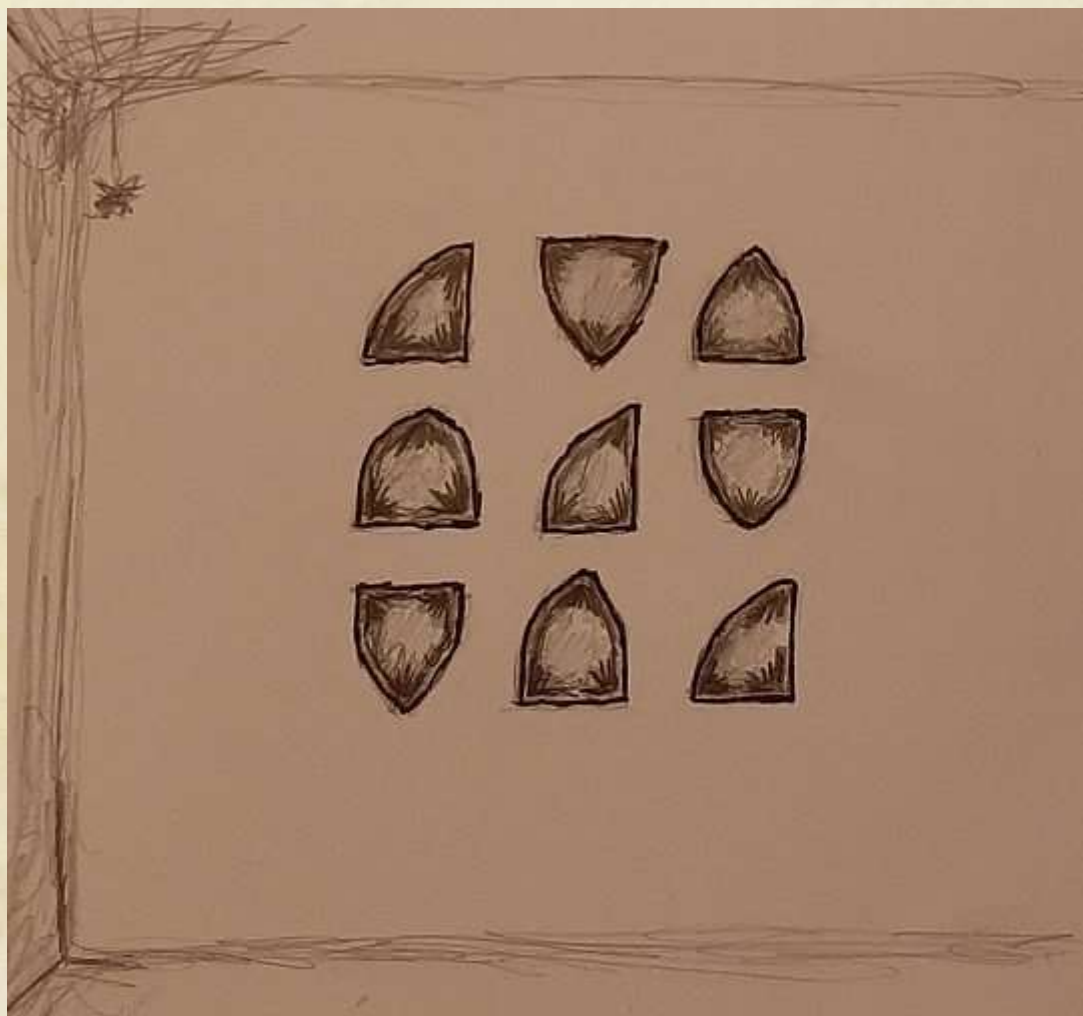


Image 3: Myrkul's Hall